

► Odin or a sorceress

This tiny silver figurine from Denmark is said to be Odin with his two ravens and two wolves. However, some believe that the seated figure is a woman—either the goddess Freyja, credited with teaching Odin sorcery, or a *volva* (wand-carrier).



water from the well to refresh the great world tree Yggdrasil, which linked the realm of gods, people, giants, and the dead. The three sat by its roots spinning the threads of life to weave the destiny of every living being. Controlling fate made them even more powerful than the gods, and they could be a force for good and evil.

Seers and sorcery

At the heart of Norse magic lay *seidhr*—sorcery practiced mainly by women, one of the origins of the idea of witches in Europe. Men did practice it, too, but for them it was considered *argr* (effeminate and therefore shameful). *Seidhr* was shamanistic, involving visionary journeys and contact with the spirit world. Although the Norns were said to control fate, it was *seidhr* that gave the power to foresee and maybe reshape it. *Seidhr* practitioners were invited to gatherings to give people predictions about their future. They often used chanting and spells to contact the gods.

The most revered sorceresses were the *volva* (wand-carriers), expert practitioners of *seidhr* described as wearing long blue cloaks with hoods lined with white cat fur and black lamb's wool. *Volva* could play tricks with the mind and the memory—shape-shifting and making things invisible—or set curses on enemies. They were linked with Freyja, who was the goddess of love, sex, and beauty. It was Freyja who was said to have taught Odin the “unmanly” art of *seidhr*.

Controlling destiny

Nordic people believed in many Norns, all female. They included elves and dwarves, but the three main Norns lived at the well of Urd (Fate) in Asgard, the home of the gods. These three carried

▼ Weaving fate

The three Norns gather next to the rock of Brúnnhilde (a Norse heroine), weaving the rope of destiny, in this illustration of the prologue to Part 4 of Richard Wagner's *Ring Cycle*, a set of operas based on Norse sagas.



“An evil Norn
In olden days
Doomed me
In waters to dwell.”

REGINSMÁL, c. 1270